

THE 7 PRINCIPLES WORKBOOK FOR COUPLES

Build Your Love Maps & Strengthen Your Marriage

Research-Based Exercises for Lasting Love

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THE RESEARCH BEHIND HAPPY MARRIAGES

After decades of research on thousands of couples, key principles emerged:

Happy couples are not perfect - they handle conflict differently.

They build deep friendship, maintain positive interactions,
and repair quickly after disagreements.

The Magic Ratio: 5 positive interactions for every 1 negative.

The Four Horsemen that predict divorce:

1. Criticism (attacking character, not behavior)
2. Contempt (disgust, superiority, disrespect)
3. Defensiveness (counter-attacking, playing victim)
4. Stonewalling (shutting down, withdrawing)

The Antidotes:

1. Gentle startup (I feel... about... I need...)
2. Build culture of appreciation
3. Take responsibility
4. Self-soothe, then re-engage

This workbook guides you through building each principle.

LOVE MAPS - PARTNER 1

How well do you know your partner's inner world?

1. Name your partner's two closest friends:

2. What is your partner's current biggest worry?

3. What is your partner's dream vacation?

4. What is your partner's favorite way to unwind?

5. Name a recent accomplishment they're proud of:

6. What is their biggest life dream right now?

7. What stresses them most at work?

8. Who was their childhood best friend?

9. What would they do with an unexpected \$10,000?

10. What is their favorite meal you could make?

11. What is their deepest fear?

12. What makes them feel most loved?

13. What is their favorite way to spend a Saturday?

14. Name something on their bucket list:

15. What is their love language?

16. What family member are they closest to?

17. What would their ideal retirement look like?

18. What song reminds them of your relationship?

19. What do they wish you did more of?

20. What are they most grateful for right now?

LOVE MAPS - PARTNER 2

How well do you know your partner's inner world?

1. Name your partner's two closest friends:

2. What is your partner's current biggest worry?

3. What is your partner's dream vacation?

4. What is your partner's favorite way to unwind?

5. Name a recent accomplishment they're proud of:

6. What is their biggest life dream right now?

7. What stresses them most at work?

8. Who was their childhood best friend?

9. What would they do with an unexpected \$10,000?

10. What is their favorite meal you could make?

11. What is their deepest fear?

12. What makes them feel most loved?

13. What is their favorite way to spend a Saturday?

14. Name something on their bucket list:

15. What is their love language?

16. What family member are they closest to?

17. What would their ideal retirement look like?

18. What song reminds them of your relationship?

19. What do they wish you did more of?

20. What are they most grateful for right now?

FONDNESS & ADMIRATION - DAYS 1-7

Each day, tell your partner one thing you appreciate about them.

Day 1 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 2 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 3 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 4 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 5 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 6 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 7 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

FONDNESS & ADMIRATION - DAYS 8-14

Each day, tell your partner one thing you appreciate about them.

Day 8 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 9 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 10 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 11 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 12 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 13 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

Day 14 Date: ____/____/____

What I appreciate: _____

Their response: _____

How it made me feel: _____

TURNING TOWARD - BID TRACKING

A 'bid' is any attempt to connect. Track how you respond.

Day 1

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

Day 2

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

Day 3

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

Day 4

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

TURNING TOWARD - BID TRACKING

A 'bid' is any attempt to connect. Track how you respond.

Day 5

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

Day 6

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

Day 7

Bid received: _____

My response: ☐ Turned Toward ☐ Turned Away ☐ Turned Against

Bid I made: _____

Partner's response: ☐ Toward ☐ Away ☐ Against

THE FOUR HORSEMEN - ASSESSMENT

CRITICISM

Attacking character vs. complaining about behavior

Antidote: Gentle startup - 'I feel ____ about ____ and I need ____'

When I do this: _____

Instead I will: _____

CONTEMPT

Disgust, eye-rolling, name-calling, mockery

Antidote: Build culture of appreciation and respect

When I do this: _____

Instead I will: _____

DEFENSIVENESS

Counter-attacking, whining, playing victim

Antidote: Accept responsibility for even a small part

When I do this: _____

Instead I will: _____

STONEWALLING

Shutting down, withdrawing, silent treatment

Antidote: Self-soothe (20 min break), then re-engage

When I do this: _____

Instead I will: _____

FOUR HORSEMEN - WEEKLY CHECK-IN

Track instances this week. Tally marks.

Criticism: Me _____ | Partner _____

Antidote used: _____

Contempt: Me _____ | Partner _____

Antidote used: _____

Defensiveness: Me _____ | Partner _____

Antidote used: _____

Stonewalling: Me _____ | Partner _____

Antidote used: _____

REPAIR ATTEMPTS MENU

20 phrases to use when things get heated:

1. I'm sorry. Please forgive me.
2. Can we take a break and come back to this?
3. I can see my part in this.
4. Let me start again in a softer way.
5. I love you. This is hard but we'll get through it.
6. Tell me what you need right now.
7. I'm getting flooded. I need 20 minutes.
8. Can I have a do-over?
9. You're right. I hadn't thought of it that way.
10. I appreciate you telling me how you feel.
11. One thing I admire about you is...
12. I feel defensive. Can you say that more gently?
13. We're on the same team here.
14. What can I do to make this better right now?
15. I hear you. That makes sense.
16. I'm grateful you're willing to work on this with me.
17. Help me understand your perspective better.
18. This isn't about winning. I want us both to feel heard.
19. Let's find a compromise we can both live with.
20. I believe in us.

My favorite repairs (circle 5 above). My partner's favorites:

CREATING SHARED MEANING: RITUALS OF CONNECTION

Morning ritual:

Reunion ritual:

Bedtime ritual:

Weekly date:

Annual traditions:

CREATING SHARED MEANING: ROLES IN OUR RELATIONSHIP

How we divide household tasks:

How we make financial decisions:

How we parent (or plan to):

How we handle extended family:

How we support each other's careers:

CREATING SHARED MEANING: SHARED GOALS

1-year goals together:

5-year goals together:

Lifetime dreams together:

How we'll support each other:

What we'll sacrifice for these:

CREATING SHARED MEANING: SYMBOLS & STORIES

Songs that define us:

Our origin story:

Inside jokes:

Places that matter to us:

Objects that symbolize our love:

DREAMS WITHIN CONFLICT

Behind every gridlocked conflict is an unfulfilled dream.

The issue we keep fighting about:

My position:

My partner's position:

The dream behind MY position:

Where this dream comes from (history):

The dream behind MY PARTNER'S position:

(Ask them - don't assume)

Areas of flexibility (where I can give):

Core areas (non-negotiable for me):

A temporary compromise we can try:

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 1

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 2

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 3

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 4

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 5

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 6

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 7

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

STATE OF THE UNION MEETING - WEEK 8

Date: ___/___/___ Duration: ___ minutes

APPRECIATIONS (5 things I appreciated this week):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

ISSUES TO PROCESS (use gentle startup):

Issue: _____

My feeling: _____

My need: _____

Partner's perspective: _____

Compromise reached: _____

UPCOMING EVENTS & LOGISTICS:

FUN PLANNED THIS WEEK:

HOW WE'RE DOING (rate 1-10):

Friendship: ___ Intimacy: ___ Fun: ___ Teamwork: ___

OUR RELATIONSHIP VISION

In 1 year, our relationship will be:

In 5 years:

In 20 years:

The kind of couple we want to be:

How we want others to describe us:

Our shared life mission:

What we commit to doing differently:

Signed:

Partner 1: _____ Date: __/__/__

Partner 2: _____ Date: __/__/__